DECCAN LORDS

LIVING GAME BIBLE

Vision Capture • Version 0.1 • 15 October 2026

A living specification for a stylized, atmospheric strategy sandbox set in early-modern India. Built collaboratively; not all ideas are approved or in scope.

STATUS: DISCOVERY IN PROGRESS — NO NEW GAMEPLAY MECHANICS LOCKED

How to use this bible

The Markdown folder inside the companion ZIP is the canonical editable source. This Word file is a readable snapshot. The companion workbook tracks statuses, open questions, and system inventory. When sources conflict, use the latest dated entry in the decision log after discussing the change.

Status vocabulary: LOCKED = explicitly approved; PROPOSED = recommendation, not commitment; OPEN = unresolved; DEFERRED = later; REJECTED = explicitly excluded; RESEARCH = verification required.

Important: the previous GDD marked a smaller Deccan-focused design as “skeleton locked.” The expanded vision in this conversation reopens some of its decisions, including geographic scale, starting assets, technology direction, and future multiplayer. This bible records that tension rather than silently erasing the older document.

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00 — Vision and design pillars

Working pitch

A stylized, atmospheric PC strategy sandbox inspired by the approachable resource-and-army loops of classic RTS games, the satisfying settlement development of economic builders, and the emergent political life of a medieval/early-modern sandbox. The player begins as a young heir to a once-influential Deccan clan. With only a modest inheritance and reduced authority, the player must decide whether to serve a Sultan, rebuild the clan, become a mercenary or outlaw, establish an independent kingdom, or pursue greater sovereignty. Villages are inhabited communities with needs and loyalties—not empty tiles or interchangeable resource nodes.

This is a working pitch, not final marketing copy.

Player fantasy

“I inherited a fragile position in a living, politically complicated world. My choices help determine whether my family survives, my people prosper, my neighbors become allies or enemies, and whether I remain a vassal or rise to rule.”

Intended emotional range

1. **Peaceful satisfaction:** build, improve, trade, watch work happen, and enjoy atmosphere and music.
2. **Readable action:** command forces, defend a settlement, raid, maneuver, besiege, and fight over meaningful objectives.
3. **Political agency:** relationships, promises, reputation, favors, ambition, and allegiance matter.
4. **Emergent stories:** NPCs make understandable but not fully predictable decisions; the player can recover from setbacks but can also lose power.
5. **Approachable surface, deep systems:** players can understand immediate needs and goals without needing to master every formula.

Design pillars — proposed

- **The world is inhabited.** Capturing land means governing people, loyalties, livelihoods and local power—not merely changing a map color.
- **Power is interconnected.** Population supports production and recruitment; production supports armies; geography affects trade and war; politics affects whether forces can safely be used.
- **The player's path is open.** Service, independence, trade, conquest, mercenary work and outlaw paths are possible ambitions, subject to later scope decisions.
- **Geography matters.** Passes, hills, rivers, roads, coasts, weather and distance should create decisions, not just decoration.
- **CPU behavior has reasons.** Decisions arise from goals, personality, information, relationships, constraints and opportunities. Randomness adds variation but does not replace reasoning.
- **A polished, cohesive experience beats raw feature count.** Animation, sound, readable UI, frame pacing and feedback are part of the design.

Audience and modes — intended outcomes, exact feature set OPEN

- Accessible enough for people who enjoy settlement-building and straightforward competitive games but do not identify as strategy experts.
- Deep enough for players who enjoy long campaigns, economic optimization, diplomacy and military planning.
- A long-session, low-pressure play style should coexist with focused battles and shorter competitive play. Whether these use separate modes/rulesets is OPEN.
- Single-player CPU campaign is the first delivery priority. Cooperative and competitive multiplayer are future goals, not assumed v1 features.

Tone and visual ambition

Aim for a beautiful, readable, stylized 3D strategy world with a three-quarter/isometric-like camera, coherent regional architecture, atmospheric natural lighting, believable movement, satisfying combat feedback and a memorable soundscape. The Three.js screenshot/prototype is a visual reference, not a final quality ceiling. “AAA feel” means strong cohesion and polish; it does not imply AAA asset volume or production budget.

What success should feel like

A player can understand the first useful choice quickly, care about the settlement and its people, experience consequences from a decision, and later tell a story about how they rose or fell in a world that appeared to act for its own reasons.

01 — Opening and player journey

The proposed starting premise

The player is a young successor to a Deccan clan. Their father was a capable warlord and noble who served more than one major ruler over his life, built a respected local network, and maintained both friendships and feuds. After the father's death or political transition (exact event OPEN), the Sultan does not entrust the young heir with the father's former high authority. A more experienced lord receives important responsibility; the heir retains a modest ancestral base: some villages, a town or market center, basic fortifications and limited clan property, but not a royal estate or an empire.

This creates an immediate reason to play: prove worth to the Sultan, rebuild the clan, negotiate with neighbors, seek another patron, or pursue independence. The father's old friends may help; rivals may see the transition as an opportunity to erase the clan's influence.

Narrative details not final: starting date, exact inheritance, father's fate, identity of the initial Sultan/faction, exact number of villages/town/forts, whether the opening is playable or cinematic, and which rival is the initial antagonist.

Opening sequence — to be designed

Candidate flow:

1. Title / new game / settings / accessibility.
2. Choose a campaign setup (whether to choose historical start, difficulty, or sandbox rules is OPEN).
3. Briefly establish the clan, inheritance and current political situation.
4. Show the starting territory on the strategic map and explain the immediate pressures.
5. Give the player a small set of meaningful first actions rather than presenting every system at once.
6. Allow the player to inspect a settlement, household/workforce, treasury, army, fortification and neighboring lords.
7. Introduce the first dilemma: a practical local need and a political/military opportunity or threat.

The sequence above is a hypothesis only. Do not implement until the user has described the desired first minutes in more detail.

Possible long-term player paths

- Trusted vassal / senior general.
- Loyal but increasingly autonomous regional lord.
- Independent king or founder of a kingdom.
- Power broker who supports or replaces a superior ruler.
- Merchant-oriented regional power.
- Mercenary commander.
- Bandit / outlaw leader with fragile control over land and people.
- Defeated claimant who rebuilds from a reduced position—or reaches a game-over condition.

These are desired possibilities, not all guaranteed v1 mechanics. Define what actually distinguishes the paths in gameplay before promising them as shipped features.

First-session usability principle

The player should be able to answer, at a glance:

- What do I own and control?
- What is currently going well or badly?
- What do my people need?
- What can I build, afford, recruit, or change?
- Who are my closest allies and threats?
- What could happen if I take the next action?

Questions to answer later

See Open questions, especially opening story, starting assets, time model, player character representation, and first-hour flow.

02 — World, geography and historical scope

User's current ambition

The broad ambition is a map spanning a large part of the subcontinent—from the Delhi region toward Kanyakumari—with major historical cities, towns, villages, forts, ports and local power centers. Some settlements may grow into larger towns/cities; neglected or devastated places may temporarily become ruins and later recover. The Deccan is the narrative and political starting point, not necessarily the permanent geographic limit of the dream game.

Major scale warning

A map covering most of India, with all settlements simulated at village-level detail, all lords active, evolving populations, supply convoys, wars and diplomacy, is a very large content and simulation problem. The key design decision is not simply “small map or large map”; it is **which level of detail is simulated at each scale**.

Possible layered model to evaluate:

- **Strategic layer:** regions, routes, settlements, fortresses, factions, armies and political control across a wide map.
- **Local settlement layer:** detailed construction, household needs, production and population management for owned/nearby/relevant places.
- **Tactical layer:** focused battles or siege encounters on a local battlefield.

This model is PROPOSED, not locked. We need to decide whether all the layers share one zoomable world, use different scenes, or use a hybrid.

Geography as gameplay

Candidate features from the user's vision:

- Sahyadri and other mountain ranges, hilltops and defensible passes.
- Rivers, bridges/fords and crossing points.
- Plateau farms, forests, grazing areas, roads and coastal trading centers.
- Terrain/weather affecting cultivation, travel speed, visibility, combat and siege endurance.
- Hill forts and settlements with different defensive and economic profiles.
- Routes where armies and slow supply trains can be intercepted.

Every geographical feature should support a real decision. Avoid making every terrain type a separate system if a small number of movement, visibility, production and defense modifiers can create the desired results.

Historical framing

- Existing GDD baseline: Deccan around 1660.
- Current conversation: wider 1600–1700-era Indian setting and a long-range map aspiration.
- Exact campaign year, political boundaries, named figures, faction roster, settlement roster, and historical/alternate-history boundary are OPEN.

Candidate powers mentioned by the user include Deccan sultanates, Mughal authority, Maratha/Deccan local lords, Siddis, British, Dutch, Portuguese, French, Spanish and Arab-linked trading or political groups. Presence and role must be verified against the selected date and region; do not populate the game just because a power is familiar today.

Content tiers — proposal

For manageable development, consider marking places as:

- **Playable-detail:** player-owned or locally contested settlements that use household/production/building simulation.
- **Strategic-detail:** AI-held places represented by a simpler aggregate state until the player interacts with them or they become strategically relevant.
- **Named landmark:** important historical location with defined strategic purpose and a lightweight state.

This could make a wide map possible without calculating every home and workshop at equal detail. It requires a test and explicit design decision.

Historical accuracy policy

Maintain a research ledger with: claim, region/date, source, confidence, game interpretation, and whether the mechanic departs from history for playability. User-provided local knowledge should be captured as valuable research input but not silently represented as independently verified fact. See research and decision log.

03 — Settlements, households, population and economy

Core concept from the user

The player inherits populated settlements. People are not just spawned as generic RTS worker units. Settlement growth should be driven by household housing, living conditions, fulfilled needs, safety, prosperity, migration and policy. The player assigns labor to farming, crafts, construction, military service and other roles, within the limits of available households/workforce.

Housing growth idea — PROPOSED

A small rural settlement may start with huts. Better housing can progress through house and larger clan/civic homes such as a wada. Each housing tier could increase household capacity or the number of people/family members supported (the example capacities 4/6/8/12/15 were illustrative, not chosen values). New families may arrive when living conditions and housing availability are attractive. The exact family/person/workforce abstraction is OPEN.

Candidate household needs by tier

- Basic rural households: food and fuel/firewood, water/access to essentials, safety.
- Better-off households: clothing, tools, improved services or market access.
- Wealthier households: additional goods, amenities, services, status, or luxury demands.

Needs should not become a checklist of dozens of goods by default. Each added good must create a meaningful production/trade choice. Exact needs, tiers and goods are OPEN.

Candidate economic loop

1. Households arrive, remain, grow, migrate or leave in response to conditions.
2. The player builds farms, storage, wells, homes, workshops, markets, religious/community structures and defensive works.
3. Available labor is assigned to production and services.
4. Goods are consumed, stored, traded, taxed or used by the army.
5. Tax rate, security, prices, services and shortages affect prosperity, loyalty and population.
6. Prosperity and population support more production, revenue and recruitment—but create additional demand and protection costs.

The loop needs formulas, rates, limits and test examples later. The design should favor understandable cause-and-effect rather than simulation for its own sake.

Taxes, loyalty and demands

User's concept: residents may accept higher taxes if they receive safety, services, supplies and favorable conditions; high tax with unmet needs or poor protection risks resentment, revolt, flight or decline. This is PROPOSED; the precise relationship must be tuned and explained in UI.

Settlements can change over time

Candidate stages: hamlet/village → larger village/market town → town/city, with historic centers, geography, population, trade and government affecting what is possible. Warfare or neglect may reduce prosperity, population, infrastructure or settlement status; recovery may take time. Whether a settlement can become a ruin, be permanently destroyed, or be rebuilt is OPEN.

Labor and war

Open design issue: separate professional soldiers from local levies/militia, and specify what happens to household labor when residents are mobilized. Avoid instantly losing all agriculture because every able person is called to war unless that is the intended strategic trade-off. A family/household abstraction may allow roles to change without tracking each human individually.

Production and trade

Candidate resources and goods include food/grain, timber/firewood, stone, iron, cloth, tools, livestock, weapons, gunpowder, coin and luxury/market goods. This is not a final resource list. Prefer a small core resource set with regional specializations and trade goods added only where they produce interesting decisions.

Key edge cases to specify later

Famine, bad monsoon, siege shortages, storage loss, migration, tax revolt, market access, isolated villages, disrupted roads, stolen supply, population recovery after war, production shutdown when labor or inputs are unavailable, and what persists when a settlement changes owner.

04 — Military, parties, logistics and sieges

Desired feel

Combat should offer the readability and command satisfaction of an RTS, while the wider campaign gives armies logistical and political context. The size, speed and detail of battles versus strategic movement remain OPEN.

Army and party distinctions

Candidate entity types:

- **Lord's field army:** mobile combat formation with commander, troop composition, morale, wages, speed and supply needs.
- **Garrison:** troops attached to a settlement/fortification.
- **Patrol/raiding party:** smaller force used for scouting, escorting, raids or local security.
- **Companion-led party:** an assigned commander with their own orders and configurable autonomy (future scope to assess).
- **Supply caravan/train:** separate, slower non-combat or lightly defended transport party carrying food, livestock, materials, weapons, gunpowder and siege equipment.

These are candidate categories, not locked. Decide whether they are separate simulation entities or modes of one party model.

Supply-train idea from the user

A large army may be supported by a slower convoy. Heavy loads reduce speed and may affect security. An escort protects supplies but reduces the army's available combat strength; leaving supplies behind may increase march speed but risks shortages. Enemies may raid the convoy, seize supplies or recover dropped goods. A successful defensive strike may disrupt the besieging army's camp or supplies and shorten a siege.

This creates a strong tactical/economic loop, but it risks becoming too much micromanagement. Test whether supplies can be represented with a small number of legible states before adding detailed goods and animals.

Forts, town walls and settlement defense

The user wants both customizable fortifications and geographic defensive locations. Not every settlement must be a full castle. Candidate distinctions:

- Natural refuge/hilltop stronghold.
- Small fortification or fortified manor.
- Fort controlling a pass or route.
- Walled town/city.
- Major fortress/capital.

Buildings, walls, garrisons and terrain should affect approach routes, defense, siege time, supplies, and strategic control. Exact build rules, footprint, upgrade limits, costs and siege modes are OPEN.

Sieges — desired possibilities

- Defenders ration food, water, ammunition and other essentials.
- Some civilian population contributes to defense or support, but this must have an explicit cost to local work and survival.
- Attackers require supply and a viable siege camp/encirclement.
- Relief forces, diversionary raids, sabotage, convoy interception or allied attacks can disrupt a siege.
- A weaker defender may survive through terrain, planning, stores, alliances and timing.
- Surrender, negotiated terms, relief, assault, retreat, capture and post-siege consequences need explicit outcomes.

Cannons, gunpowder artillery, specialist siege equipment and period-appropriate engineering require research and careful scope decisions. Do not assume every faction has the same equipment.

Army types and command

Infantry, cavalry and ranged units are an initial abstraction, not a finalized roster. Later decisions must cover unit roles, formations, command latency, morale, fatigue, terrain, weather, fort bonuses, retreat, capture, casualties, replenishment and how battlefield results update the campaign.

Reuse of existing prototype

The uploaded Three.js prototype already has selection/movement/combat/pathfinding mechanics that can inform requirements. Reuse is conditional on a focused technical audit. Do not port everything automatically or assume it can be copied directly into Godot.

05 — Politics, factions, companions and NPC decision-making

Political fantasy

The player begins as a local hereditary lord in a hierarchy of overlapping clan, village, fort, regional, kingdom and imperial power. Authority is not merely a map color: it may depend on allegiance, revenue, military obligation, recognition, relationships, prestige, fear, family ties and a ruler's ability to protect subordinates.

The exact number and names of political levels are OPEN. The game should not force a single linear promotion path if the player can become a rival, mercenary or outlaw.

Relationships

Candidate relationship dimensions:

- Personal relations / trust.
- Allegiance to current superior.
- Fear and estimate of military strength.
- Ambition and risk tolerance.
- Greed / material motivation.
- Reputation for keeping promises, generosity, cruelty or reliability.
- Kinship, clan ties and past events.
- Memory of a bounded set of recent meaningful actions.
- Knowledge confidence: what the NPC believes about the player and other lords.

Avoid duplicate stats that all mean “friendliness.” Each variable should have a distinct mechanical effect and visible explanation where possible.

Political actions — candidate list

Gifts, tribute, requests for support, hiring service, treaties, alliance, non-aggression, military access, trade contracts, promises, betrayal, spying, rumor, bribery, protection, vassalage, rebellion, secession, surrender, succession or election by nobles, and recognition of a new ruler. Marriage, dynasty and succession scope need special treatment and may belong in a later version.

Companion and governor ambition

The user wants companions with statistics who can be assigned to lead parties or take responsibility for territories and perhaps become allied lords/kings later. This is a major feature because delegated companions can change the scale of the world. V1 must define whether companions can only command parties or can independently govern and found higher political entities.

Candidate AI decision architecture

PROPOSED: use explainable, data-driven AI first.

- Utility scoring ranks valid options based on goals, personality, resources, relations, threats, opportunity and expected payoff.
- A planner (for example, goal-oriented action planning) can assemble steps toward goals such as raising an army or capturing a pass.
- Tactical behavior trees/state machines handle immediate unit/army execution.
- Bounded randomness and seeded testing provide variation while keeping scenarios reproducible.
- A memory/state system records significant interactions and consequences.

ML is not rejected forever. It should only enter runtime decision-making when a specific measurable problem is defined, and its behavior can be tested, bounded and kept fair. ML might first assist with offline balance analysis, playtest clustering or content generation.

Political hierarchy / player progression

Potential path: minor heir → recognized local lord → regional power/vassal or independent claimant → king/ruler of a realm → emperor or leader of a multi-king coalition. The user has suggested requiring a minimum number of holdings, forts, allied rulers and political recognition for higher status. All exact prerequisites, votes, titles, inheritance rules and consequences are OPEN.

AI personality without chaos

Different lords can share the same algorithm but have different goals, fears, budgets, geography, allies, memories, military doctrine and risk preferences. Their actions should be driven by explainable state and constraints, not arbitrary hidden advantages. Randomness should select among plausible options, not replace planning.

06 — Living world, events and consequences

Intended world behavior

The simulation should feel active even when the player is not watching a specific lord. NPC rulers may develop settlements, tax heavily, recruit, raid, negotiate, fight, change allegiance, respond to the Sultan's strength and take opportunities created by distance or terrain.

Time and simulation levels — OPEN

We need to decide whether time advances continuously, in discrete days/ticks, or through a hybrid. Long-term population and politics likely need a different update cadence from tactical battles and visual animation. Avoid making every lord run expensive full-detail logic every rendered frame.

Possible tiered update concept:

- High frequency: local combat and movement.
- Periodic: economy, household needs, supply consumption and settlement updates.
- Daily/strategic turn: diplomacy, lord goals, recruitment and world events.
- Event-driven: immediate reactions to battle outcomes, betrayal, capture, famine, treaty or succession.

This is a technical/design proposal, not a final time model.

Events should have causes

Candidate events include shortages, succession disputes, letters from superiors, tribute requests, border raids, requests for troops, a rival seeking an alliance, suspicious convoy movement, a lord asking for aid, a village refusing tax, changing monsoon conditions, bandit activity or an opportunity to attack an exposed enemy.

Events should reference actual world state and offer a small set of understandable responses. Avoid random pop-ups disconnected from the simulation.

Consequence chain example (illustrative)

High taxation + failed harvest + weak local protection → household distress → migration/unrest → lower productive labor and tax base → weakened garrison/recruitment → neighbor sees an opportunity → raid or political demand. A player who stored grain, reduced taxes, negotiated help or protected the road could avoid or alter the chain.

The exact numerical formulas are not yet defined.

Predictable rules, unpredictable outcomes

The player should learn reliable relationships, but not know every opponent's exact next move. Keep sources of uncertainty grounded: incomplete information, competing goals, random events within plausible ranges, delayed messages, weather variation and other agents' strategic choices.

Reproducibility and debugging

Store random seeds for test scenarios where possible. Log important AI choices with inputs, candidate actions, scores and selected action. A developer/debug view should explain why a lord chose war, retreat, alliance or development. This makes emergent behavior tuneable instead of mysterious.

07 — UI/UX, accessibility, art, animation and audio

UI principles

- The game should be approachable to people who enjoy strategy but are not expert RTS players.
- Show current needs, risks and consequences near the relevant decision.
- Keep map information legible at different zoom levels; use icons and color consistently.
- Detailed statistics can exist in panels, but should not overwhelm the main play view.
- Give strong feedback for selection, movement orders, construction, completed production, danger, hits, morale changes and political outcomes.
- Use tooltips and progressive disclosure rather than forcing a manual before play.
- Key actions should be accessible through clear mouse controls and meaningful shortcuts; accessibility options remain to be designed.

Candidate screen groups

Not locked: main menu/campaign setup, strategic map, local settlement management, army/party management, diplomacy/lord profile, tactical battle, siege, event/dialogue choice, codex/help, settings/save-load.

These may be overlays or scenes. We should not create a separate “screen” for every concept before the navigation flow is tested.

Visual target

Stylized 3D, three-quarter/isometric-like camera; consistent architectural and environmental language; pleasing color harmony; readable silhouettes; natural lighting; restrained VFX; smooth camera and selection feedback. The existing Three.js screenshot is a starting visual reference. It does not decide the final renderer, art direction or asset quality.

Animation priorities

Minimum quality bar for a representative slice: idle, walk/run, turn, attack, hit reaction, death/retreat, building construction or state change, and clear formation movement. Prioritize readable animation and responsiveness over huge numbers of poorly integrated animations.

Audio priorities

Layered ambient beds by biome/time/weather; distinct work, movement, weapon, impact, construction, UI and alert sounds; music that supports peaceful development and tense conflict. Music may be curated/composed separately; all third-party audio must have a verified licence and attribution record when required.

Asset production pipeline

Use a fixed art direction guide, palette/material rules, scale conventions, naming rules, animation requirements, LOD/performance budgets, and source/licence metadata. Blender and AI tools can support

asset production, but every final asset requires review for consistency, topology, rig quality, visual artifacts and commercial rights.

Definition of polish

Readable, responsive, stable and cohesive at target zoom and camera angle. Do not rely solely on bloom, particle counts or expensive graphics. Establish performance budgets early and profile on a realistic Windows PC, not only the Mac development machine.

08 — Technical architecture and AI-assisted workflow

Provisional stack direction

PROPOSED: Godot 4.x, using the latest supported stable patch at project setup, with GDScript for gameplay logic. The intent is to use an integrated game engine for scenes, 3D rendering, animation, audio, UI, input and desktop export rather than build the entire product in React/Three.js and later rewrite it. Verify the current stable version and pin it in project setup; do not use an untested development/nightly build for the main project.

Godot officially supports native macOS development and Windows desktop exporting. Reference: Godot Windows export documentation and Godot platform FAQ.

What to do with the existing Three.js prototype

- Keep it in version control as a reference/prototype.
- Audit movement, selection, combat, pathfinding, structures, resources, and screenshot style.
- Record desired behaviors and edge cases before adapting anything.
- Port or reimplement only components that are valuable and fit the chosen architecture.
- Do not build a second complete version of the campaign in React first.

A tiny React/HTML mockup is acceptable if it validates a UI interaction quickly; it must not become a parallel full-game implementation.

Architecture principles

- Simulation state is separate from rendering and UI.
- State-changing actions are explicit commands validated by game rules.
- Data for buildings, units, goods, factions and events is data-driven where useful.
- Save/load has versioned schemas and deterministic migration tests.
- AI decision logic is modular, explainable and testable independently of rendering.
- Rendering/animation runs at frame cadence; settlement and political simulation run on controlled update cadences.
- No subsystem may silently invent state transitions owned by another subsystem.
- Use Git branches/commits and automated tests for meaningful work; avoid broad unreviewed AI edits.

AI coding workflow

1. Human + assistant agree a small feature spec and acceptance criteria.
2. Codex implements only that scope.
3. Build/import/headless tests run; capture screenshots or logs for visual changes.
4. Review edge cases, performance, save compatibility and regressions.
5. Update the bible and decision log after decisions change.

Local models and paid model use

A local model via a local runtime such as Ollama may help with repetitive drafts, sample data, tests, documentation and first-pass utility code. A stronger coding model should handle architecture, complex integration, critical debugging and final reviews. Local inference can reduce external usage, but code and data still need tests and licence/security review. Never grant an untrusted model unrestricted shell, filesystem or secret access by default.

MCP policy

Add an editor MCP integration only after confirming it is maintained, compatible with the pinned Godot version, permission-scoped, and useful for real tasks. MCP is an interface to tools, not a substitute for specs, tests, version control or review.

Performance and target platforms

Primary target: Windows PC distribution. macOS is the development environment and may also be a release target. Minimum CPU/GPU/RAM, frame-rate target, resolution, army count, entity budgets and save size are OPEN and must be tested against a representative scene.

Future multiplayer preparation

Keep commands and state transitions explicit, but do not build online infrastructure before the single-player core is proven. Multiplayer would require separate choices for authority, session hosting, synchronization, persistence, rejoin behavior, anti-cheat and disconnect recovery.

09 — Future multiplayer direction

Desired long-term experience

The user imagines shared sessions in a world containing many lords, kings and emperors. A real player could join as a lower lord; friends could join other positions; players might support a higher lord, vote for a leader, negotiate policy, join armies, form coalitions, attack rival players or AI powers, and eventually compete to become a king or emperor.

This is a strong long-term product vision, but not a confirmed v1 deliverable.

Questions that make this a distinct game mode

- Can multiple human players be in the same clan/faction or only in separate lordships?
- Can a player join an existing session mid-campaign? What happens to the previous lord's state?
- Are votes binding, weighted by territory/standing, or purely political?
- Can a human ruler order an AI vassal? Can players refuse orders or rebel?
- What happens when the human king logs off, disconnects or becomes inactive?
- Is the world persistent between sessions or saved only by a host?
- How long are sessions expected to run?
- What prevents griefing, collusion, exploits, and one player locking others out of meaningful play?
- Which campaign rules must be deterministic or server-authoritative?

Recommendation

Design the single-player state model so that key actions are explicit and systems are independently testable. Once the campaign is fun, select one target first: cooperative battle, competitive skirmish, or persistent political session. Do not attempt all three networking models at once.

Status

DEFERRED for implementation; retained as a design goal. No network protocol, matchmaking, backend or multiplayer feature list is locked yet.

10 — Scope and delivery approach

Primary recommendation

Use Godot for the main build after a small engine validation slice. Do not implement the entire game in React/HTML and then rebuild it in Godot; that duplicates systems, creates divergent behavior and consumes time. Keep the current Three.js project as a reference and selectively reuse/port mechanics after inspection.

Milestone sequence — provisional

Stage A — Vision and proof of direction

- Keep this living bible as the source of truth.
- Finalize the intended view/camera and broad time/scale model.
- Build a Godot scene with a small landscape, one settlement, a few buildings, animated units, camera/selection/movement, lighting, ambient sound and a simple combat interaction.
- Verify the scene imports/exports, runs acceptably on target hardware and provides the desired feel.

Stage B — Core vertical slice

- Playable opening scenario with inherited holdings.
- One local settlement with a first-pass household/workforce and production model.
- One field army and one fortification.
- One AI lord with a goal and one meaningful political interaction.
- One battle that changes the campaign state.
- Save/load, tutorial/help and basic debug logs.

Stage C — Integrated campaign prototype

- Strategic map routes and settlement control.
- A small number of active lords/factions with different goals.
- Economy, recruitment, supplies, relationships, events and outcomes integrated.
- Test a complete loop: improve settlement → make decision → face reaction → recover/reward/consequence.

Stage D — Content and presentation expansion

- Add regions, settlements, units, structures, events, sound, animation, balance and UI only after the core loop is enjoyable and testable.

Stage E — Release hardening

- Performance profiling, save/load recovery, onboarding, accessibility, installer/export pipeline, playtests, bug fixing, licensing and storefront preparation.

Timings are intentionally not promised yet. Scope and the available work schedule are not established well enough for honest estimates.

Scope controls

- Separate the dream-game map from the first playable map/content set.
- Prefer simplified aggregate simulation for distant or irrelevant locations if that meets the desired world feel.
- Add a resource/building/stat only when it creates a decision worth the complexity.
- Test any new system with a concrete player scenario and edge cases.
- Do not call the game ready because it compiles; require a playable, repeatable loop and defined quality bar.

Definition of vertical-slice success

A player can start, understand the clan's immediate situation, manage a settlement, issue an army command, interact with a lord, experience a simulated consequence, fight or avoid a battle, and save/reload without state corruption. The slice should also demonstrate the intended art and audio quality at target performance.

11 — Open questions for discussion

These are prompts, not a questionnaire the user must answer all at once. Work through them in the order that naturally comes up in conversation.

A. Opening and player identity

1. What exactly happens to the father: death, retirement, betrayal, reassignment, or a selectable backstory?
2. What year does the game begin? Is the world a historically grounded alternate history or a more freely evolving simulation?
3. What does the player personally control: a lord's character, a clan/faction, or both?
4. What are the exact initial holdings: number/type of villages, town, fort(s), households, treasury, troops and allies?
5. Is the player named/customized, and do personal stats matter in v1?

B. Map scale and zoom

6. Is India-wide coverage a launch requirement or a long-term ambition?
7. How are strategic map, local town building and tactical battlefield connected?
8. Are all settlements editable, or do distant places use aggregate simulation until relevant?
9. Which locations are essential for the first playable region?

C. Settlements and population

10. Is the basic unit a person, family/household, or workforce point?
11. What exactly does a housing upgrade increase: people, families, labor, tax, status, or a combination?
12. What goods/services do households need at each tier?
13. Which needs must be fulfilled continuously versus supplied periodically?
14. How do tax, safety, prosperity, culture/religion and ruler reputation affect migration and unrest?
15. Can settlements be permanently destroyed, temporarily ruined, captured intact, or rebuilt?

D. Economy and logistics

16. What are the core resources and which are goods versus abstract values?
17. Are supplies transported on separate map entities, attached to armies, or both?
18. How is a convoy loaded, escorted, raided, captured or recovered?
19. How are trade routes, market access, prices and regional specialties represented?

E. Military and forts

20. Which units are available at the start, and how do local levies differ from professional troops?
21. Are battles fully real-time, pausable real-time, or a separate tactical scenario?
22. How are army size, command responsiveness, morale and retreat handled?

23. What can be built/customized in a fort or a walled town?
24. How should siege food, relief armies, camps, artillery, surrender and post-siege outcomes work?

F. Politics and NPCs

25. What are the political ranks and the powers/obligations at each rank?
26. What makes a ruler accept another lord as king/emperor—military force, votes, relations, treaties, recognition or a combination?
27. Which actions affect trust, fear, honor/reputation and allegiance?
28. Can companions govern, recruit followers, become nobles, or found their own polities in the first release?
29. Which decisions must NPCs explain to the player?

G. Style, UX and competitive goals

30. Is the view fixed/isometric-like, freely rotated 3D, or a controlled hybrid?
31. Which three visual references matter most, and what should not be copied from each?
32. Should the first experience be mostly peaceful, tutorialized through threats, or immediately military?
33. Do competitive modes use the same progression and economy as campaign, or a balanced ruleset?

H. Historical and ethical research

34. Which regions, peoples, titles, terms and institutions does the user want represented accurately?
35. How should warfare, captivity, looting, slavery, religious institutions and civilian harm be represented in tone and age rating?
36. What level of historical fidelity is desired when it conflicts with strategic balance or player freedom?

Suggested immediate conversation order

Start with the opening scene and initial inheritance. Then define the map scale, the day-to-day play loop, settlement growth, army/logistics, political hierarchy and finally long-term win/lose states. Record new ideas before locking formulas.

12 — Decision log

Use one entry per meaningful decision. When a decision changes, keep the old entry and add a new one with date, reason, and affected documents. Do not erase design history silently.

D-001 — Product goal [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: PC strategy sandbox combining approachable RTS loops, settlement development, political sandbox play, and reactive NPC lords

Next action: Refine player journey and audience priorities

D-002 — Setting [OPEN]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: OPEN

Current record: 17th-century India/deep Deccan focus; exact start year and launch map scale unresolved

Next action: Pick year and first playable region after user shares desired details

D-003 — Starting story [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: Young heir to a respected but politically constrained clan inherits modest villages/town/fortifications after father's legacy; Sultan entrusts greater power to an experienced lord

Next action: Define event, holdings, allies, rivals and first dilemma

D-004 — Main engine [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: Godot 4.x stable for the main PC game; preserve Three.js prototype as reference and selectively reuse logic

Next action: Validate with one representative scene before full migration

D-005 — React/HTML prototype [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: Do not build the complete campaign in React first; use lightweight mockups only when useful

Next action: Proceed directly to a Godot vertical slice after requirements are clearer

D-006 — Simulation model [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: Separate rendering from simulation; use controlled update cadence and data-driven systems

Next action: Define state/time model later

D-007 — NPC AI [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | Status: PROPOSED

Current record: Start with utility scoring/planning/tactical state machines and explainable randomness; evaluate ML only for a measured benefit

Next action: Design a sample lord decision model after core gameplay loop is described

D-008 — Population [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | **Status: PROPOSED**

Current record: Inhabited settlements; housing/household growth, labor roles, demand fulfilment, taxes and safety affect prosperity/loyalty

Next action: Decide household versus person abstraction and growth rules

D-009 — Logistics [PROPOSED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | **Status: PROPOSED**

Current record: Separate supply convoy may travel slower than army and be raided/intercepted

Next action: Test whether this creates fun without excessive micromanagement

D-010 — Multiplayer [DEFERRED]

Date: 2026-10-15 | **Status: DEFERRED**

Current record: Long-term vision for session-based players taking lord roles, alliances, votes and wars; not first implementation target

Next action: Revisit after single-player campaign loop is proven

D-011 — Geographic scale [OPEN]

Date: 2026-10-15 | **Status: OPEN**

Current record: User's long-range vision extends Delhi to Kanyakumari; detailed launch footprint and per-location simulation are undecided

Next action: Compare full-map abstraction versus regional launch

D-012 — Art style [OPEN]

Date: 2026-10-15 | **Status: OPEN**

Current record: Existing prototype is a visual reference; target is polished stylized 3D with atmospheric audio and readable battles

Next action: Build Godot art/animation benchmark scene

Change log

v0.1 — 2026-10-15

Captured the user's expanded vision and key open questions. No detailed formulas, exact content counts, release scope or historical faction roster have been locked by this file.

13 — Relationship to the earlier GDD v1.0

The earlier document was titled **DECCAN LORDS — Game Design Document, Version 1.0 (Skeleton Locked), dated 2026-10-14.** It is retained as a historical reference rather than automatically discarded.

Prior design commitments worth re-evaluating, not blindly inheriting

The earlier GDD specified a Deccan map around 1660, a player beginning as a minor lord with one village, about 20 troops and 100 coin, five core resources (grain, timber, iron, cloth, coin), three unit types (infantry, cavalry, archers), a compact v1 map, a population model based on inhabited villages, four main screens, rule-based NPC reactions, and exclusion of multiplayer/ML/LLM dialogue from v1.

Where the current vision expands or reopens the earlier design

- The geographic ambition now extends across a much larger part of India, from Delhi toward Kanyakumari; launch scope versus future expansion is OPEN.
- The starting inheritance now includes a clan's history, neighboring friends/rivals, a town and potentially several villages/fortifications; exact starting assets OPEN.
- Housing tiers, household/family growth, differentiated needs, migration and urban growth are more prominent than in the earlier compact simulation.
- Separate supply caravans, animal/livestock transport, raids on logistics, relief efforts and deeper sieges are newly emphasized.
- Political progression could include subordinate lords, companion-led territories, kingship/emperorship, votes and alliances; exact rules and version scope OPEN.
- Session-based multiplayer is a long-term ambition. It remains deferred until the single-player systems are proven, but its requirements should influence modular state/command design.
- The earlier GDD used React + Canvas 2D; the current provisional technical recommendation is Godot 4.x for the main 3D PC game. This requires validation, not an untested rewrite.
- ML was excluded from runtime AI in the old GDD. The current position remains rules/planning first, but allows later experiments if there is a measurable, bounded use case.

Preservation rule

When a new idea conflicts with the earlier GDD, record the conflict and resolve it in the decision log. Do not assume either the older GDD or a later casual idea automatically wins without discussion.